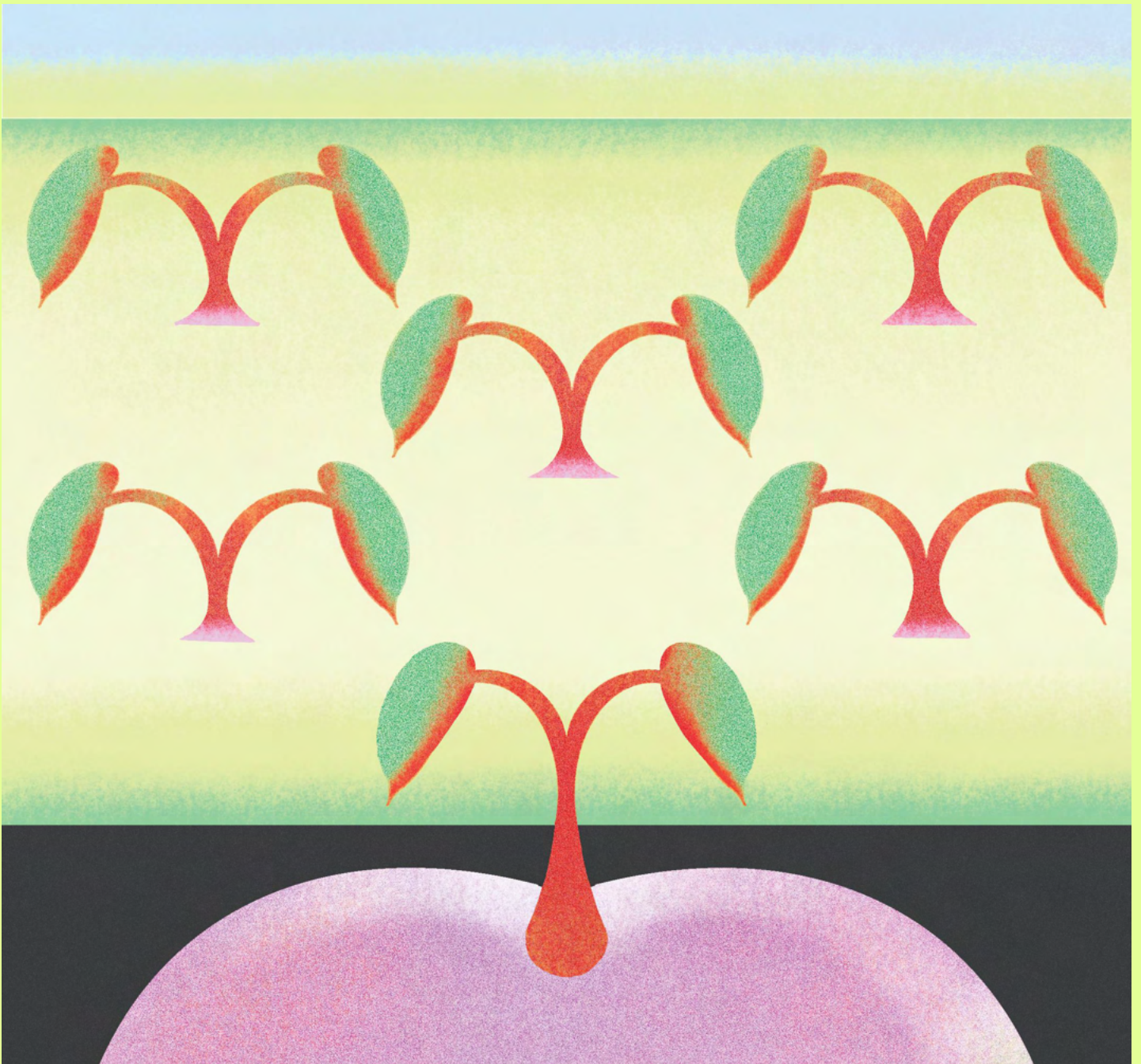




What product leaders should care about in the age of AI

How products take shape—and shape our world



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As AI promises to transform workflows and save time, it's easy to lose sight of the higher-order effects tied to the technology. Here, we explore how leaders can realize the full potential of AI while helping their teams navigate change. Experts from Stripe, LinkedIn, Perplexity, and more take stock of where we stand, what the limits are, and where we're bound to grow in this rapidly evolving field.

What is good product design in the age of AI?

Noah Levin, Vice President of Design, Figma

As AI democratizes product development, design will be the differentiator. But what exactly does "good" look like, and what does it mean for our craft?

Just as the iPhone's arrival in 2007 ushered in a new era of mobile-first design, AI underscores the things we know to be true: It takes time—and a healthy dose of experimentation—to uncover the design patterns that will unlock the full potential of a new technology. In the early days of mobile, many companies simply crammed their existing desktop experiences onto smaller screens in a race to adapt. Today, we find ourselves at a similar inflection point. We're already seeing a flood of simple chatbots and templated solutions that, while a bit clumsy, are brimming with potential. As designers, it's up to us to unlock this potential with rich interactions, intuitive gestures, and patterns that fit the medium as we did for mobile.

"As designers, it's up to us to unlock this potential with rich interactions, intuitive gestures, and patterns that fit the medium as we did for mobile."

Noah Levin, Vice President of Design, Figma

AI's ability to generate code, designs, and even entire applications from simple prompts will enable teams to go from concept to creation faster than ever, while also inviting more people to participate in that process. In this future, design will be even more important to making those products stand out. But what does good design actually look like in the age of AI? And how do you guide a team toward greatness when the technology is changing so rapidly?

At Figma, we're actively exploring these questions. We believe that AI presents a tremendous opportunity for designers, but realizing its full potential will require a deep understanding of what makes for meaningful experiences. Instead of chasing the latest trends or building for technology's sake, we should ground our work in the timeless principles of our craft—empathy, creativity, and a dedication to solving real user needs.

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In the following perspectives from our designers, we explore these questions and share our thoughts on the future of design in the age of AI. From establishing algorithmic foundations to imagining new models of co-creation, we examine how we're building AI-powered products that don't just automate design, but elevate it, and why we believe the role of the designer—no matter how it evolves—is more important than ever.

On codifying the fundamentals of good design

When we first began building [First Draft](#), our AI feature for generating a UI using design systems, we knew that we needed to teach AI the mechanics of good design. Part of that was articulating our own definition of “good.” Like many other AI products, First Draft works by creatively hacking large language models (LLMs) to perform tasks. Text-based by nature, LLMs are tremendously useful for work like writing or coding—tasks oriented around text—but it takes a greater leap to get an LLM to generate good visual work, such as UI design.

We quickly realized that we couldn’t just hand off an all-encompassing set of design rules. Not only is it impossible to define every minutiae of what “good” is into something finite, but even if we could, token limits make it technically infeasible to feed AI a monster prompt of rules. Instead, we had to reduce the principles of good design to a small, but mighty, set of guidelines that hold generally true for any UI.

Oscar Dumlao was previously a Product Designer on the Machine Learning Platform team at Figma, building First Draft, which helps users go from zero to one when generating product UI.

“Instead, we had to reduce the principles of good design to a small, but mighty, set of guidelines that hold generally true for any UI.”

Oscar Dumlao, former Product Designer, Figma

This brought me back to my days teaching design. When you have to teach, you're forced to deconstruct your own intuitive understanding into a few clear principles someone else can run with. The real challenge lies in finding rules that are clear, concrete, and instructive, while also being reliably true given any use case. These two criteria are often at odds with each other, which is why this deconstruction process is so difficult. Instructions like "always place the primary action at the bottom of a screen" or "always measure in 8px increments" strike this balance—they're specific enough to be practically applicable, yet universal enough to be helpful for nearly any UI someone might want to create. By focusing on communicating these high-leverage design truths to the AI, we were able to significantly increase the quality of First Draft's outputs within just a few weeks.

While websites and apps seem infinitely varied, we found that pretty much all of the software we use can be boiled down to just a few core layouts. While this has sparked some discourse in the design industry around homogeneity, we should also remember that these familiar patterns help people more comfortably and easily navigate technology. By having First Draft master those foundational compositions first, rather than endless permutations, we were able to establish a solid baseline. This algorithmic baseline is the new creative starting line. As AI will always produce the standard, most conventional approach, it will also be the role of the designer to bring new ideas to the table. After all, AI trained on the past can't invent the future.

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On tightening the loop from design to code

As AI tools support the workflows of both designers and engineers, their core skill sets will evolve to meet the demands of this new paradigm. Designers may acquire more technical knowledge to better understand the capabilities and limitations of AI tools, while engineers may develop a stronger grasp of design principles to create more user-centric solutions. While the final outputs may look similar, how they get there will become increasingly efficient and collaborative.

This is similar to the role of the design engineer today. In many cases, a “design engineer” started out as a designer who wanted to build their ideas, or an engineer who wanted to make their UI look better. They took the time to cultivate new skills, flexing into the other discipline. In the future, I see more of us evolving into this multifaceted “product builder” archetype—creative individuals who can leverage AI to realize their visions with ease and fluidity. But even as the boundaries between disciplines blur, I believe there will always be a place for specialized roles and skills. Designers will continue to craft exceptional user experiences while engineers will focus their time on building robust and scalable systems. AI might assist by generating layout suggestions or code snippets, but the final creative direction and technical implementation will still rely on human expertise. As AI becomes more integrated into this process, we can expect a more seamless loop between design and development.

Jordan Singer was previously a Product Designer on the Machine Learning Platform team at Figma. Before that, he was the Founder and CEO at Diagram, acquired by Figma in June 2023.

On the power of pragmatism

For me, good design in the age of AI is about leveraging today's technologies in pragmatic, high-impact ways. There's so much low-hanging fruit with what AI can reliably do right now. Search is the perfect example. You spend all this time just looking for the right stuff—digging through files, bugging teammates for links, trying to find that one component or asset you need. With AI-assisted search, you can instantly retrieve exactly what you need just by describing it in plain language. Visual search takes this a step further, allowing you to locate a specific design within your organization by simply uploading a screenshot.

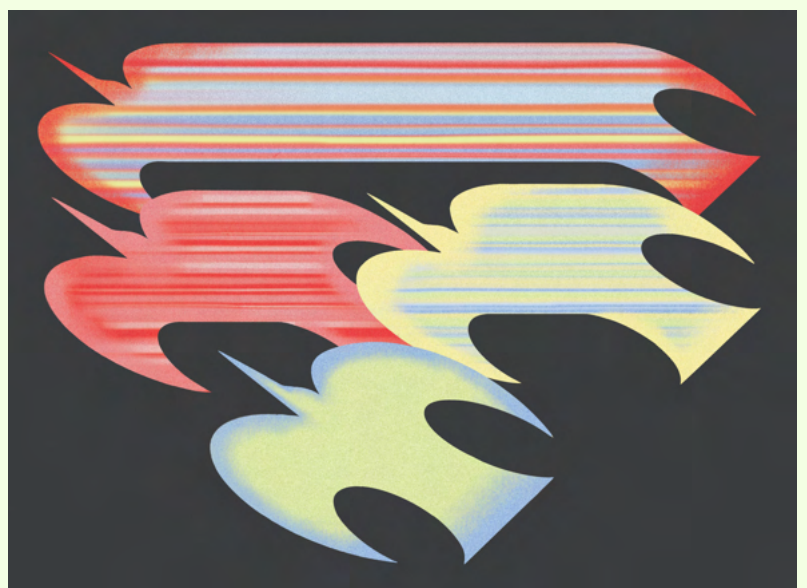
AI-assisted search also has the potential to breathe new life into the countless design explorations that never see the light of day. So much valuable work ends up in the "design graveyard," never to be seen or referenced again. But with the power of AI, all of that work can be easily retrieved, serving as a source of inspiration or helping to unblock you creatively. By making it easier to access and learn from past work, designers can spend less time searching and more time focusing on the essence of our craft—going deeper on polish and delivering better informed, more seamless experiences.

Marco Cornacchia is a Product Designer on the Machine Learning Platform team at Figma, designing AI experiences. He was the founding Product Designer at Diagram.

The key is to mesh AI into our existing processes in a thoughtful, incremental way. Rather than chasing an overhyped vision of an omniscient “AI assistant” before the technology is truly ready, we should focus on the readily attainable value that AI can reliably provide right now. Features like AI-assisted search and automated layer renaming may seem small, but they have the capability to provide real, tangible benefits to our everyday workflows. By starting with what works reliably and learning quickly through iteration, we can let AI’s role steadily expand in lockstep with its evolving capabilities over time. This incremental approach paves the way for more advanced AI applications in the future, ensuring that we don’t overreach and risk disappointment in the short term.

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Marco Cornacchia, Product Designer, Figma



On leaning into a model of co-creation

My team keeps coming back to this idea of “co-creation.” Rather than siloed tools spitting out context-free outputs, we need AI that intelligently anticipates our needs and adapts in a complementary way. The key is that AI is only going to be as helpful as its awareness of what you’re actually doing day-to-day. Right now we compensate by prompting users for more context, but we need AI that proactively knows our specific goals, our established design systems, past work, and project contexts.

This kind of design doesn’t just serve; it collaborates, offering a co-creation model where the tool enhances your creative process rather than simply automating it. For example, instead of prompting everything into existence from scratch, the AI should improve things as you work, much like how GitHub’s Copilot assists developers. It shouldn’t do the work for you; it should work with you to bring your ideas to life. This approach allows us to move beyond the role of mere users to that of creators, working alongside AI that truly understands and supports our workflows.

Natasha Tenggoro is a Product Designer at Figma, currently leading FigJam’s AI efforts. She kickstarted design for Figma’s first AI launch, Jambot, and recently led design for FigJam’s AI launch, focused on making meetings easier to run and facilitate.

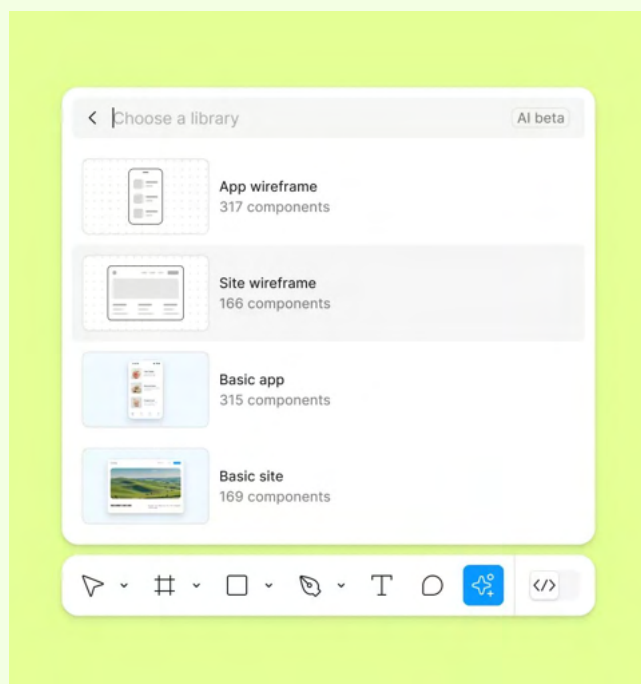
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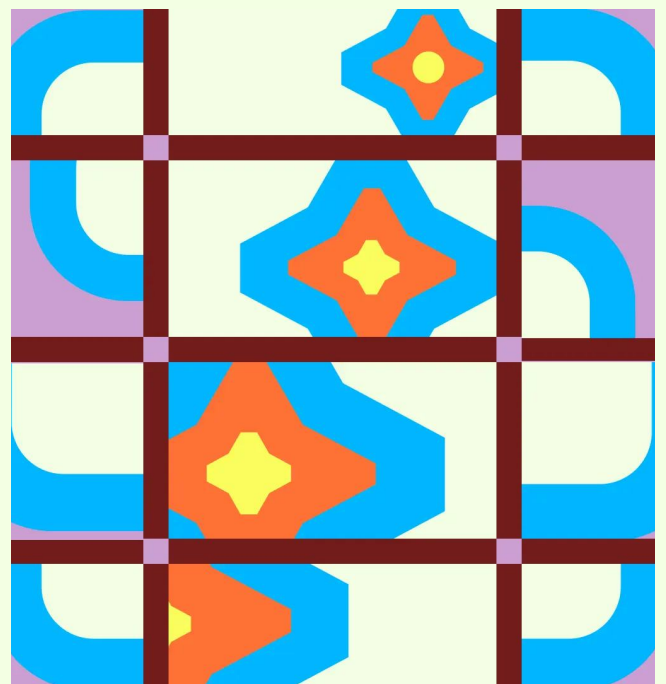
Imagine a future where, after wrapping up a planning session in FigJam, an AI can instantly grasp the meeting notes, priorities, and action items tagged across your boards. It could then intelligently suggest next steps, such as creating a roadmap to visualize Q3 initiatives or drafting a presentation deck to summarize key takeaways. By indexing your team's prior work, the AI infuses those outputs with your unique styles, methods, and visual language, extending your team's specific way of working rather than regurgitating generic templates. This is the promise of AI-powered co-creation—a future where technology enhances and elevates the creative process.

Related reading

Building a better First Draft for designers



Meet Figma AI: Empowering designers with intelligent tools



John Maeda asks if efficiency is the enemy of creativity

John Maeda, VP Engineering, Head of Computational Design / AI Platform

John Maeda shares takeaways from his 2024 Design in Tech Report, thoughts on designing with AI, and why we should embrace uphill thinking in a world optimized for shortcuts.

We find ourselves in an era of paradox. On one hand, AI promises unparalleled efficiency and limitless potential for creatives. On the other, it threatens to spawn a masterful new generation of cookie-cutter designs that could spell the end of many creative careers. So which is true? And how do we reconcile these two contradictory perspectives?

I've been talking about AI for a while. In my 2018 and 2019 Design in Tech Reports, I talked about AI's growing design applications. The response—if any—was minor. Perhaps this was because AI and its capabilities were still fairly nascent, and the technology had a long way to go before it could truly replace design jobs. Fast forward, and the topic is unavoidable. Designers worldwide are taking strides to "speak machine." They're learning how to collaborate with AI, training LLMs with datasets and fine-tuning their outputs to better align with the designer's visions—effectively bridging the gap between human creativity and the computational capabilities of AI. Designers do so fully knowing that any magic that they create with this technology may then be easily repeated, with or without them.

Dating back to 2015, the Design in Tech Report is an annual publication that explores the influence of design in the tech industry.



ttwqwerty (1998)



ttwballoon (1998)

TAP, TYPE, WRITE (1998) in the permanent collection of MoMA and most recently on display in "Never Alone Video Games and Other Interactive Design" (2022–23).

Will I wake up one morning to discover that there's an AI system named "JOhn M43d4" on Fiverr repping my work for pennies, Black Mirror-style? I'm not worried about it, because I know that's long been happening of my own accord: In the '90s, I had a certain way of creating images algorithmically that was special at the time. I open-sourced the approach at MIT as a way to get more people to turn what few secrets I had gathered into their own magic.

I had the fortune of playing a role in the creation of [MIT Scratch](#) (programming for kids), [Processing](#) (programming for designers), and a few other non-traditional coding environments because of my early belief in coding as a creative practice.

But not every magician wants to reveal their secrets—they have livelihoods to protect. So what should a designer in the era of AI's rapid ascent do? I have good news: There are plenty of things that computers are not good at. And most are things designers really don't get all that much joy from doing in the first place—mundane tasks like creating endless variations of slides, mockups, and retouches. If the computer could take on some of that work, might it give designers more time to do something else?

My dear artist friend Jessie Shefrin once said to me, "By the time you come to the perfect solution, the problem has already changed." By that thinking, what present-day problems could computers tackle today, so we can focus on tomorrow's?

"By the time you come to the perfect solution, the problem has already changed."

Jessie Shefrin, artist

To begin, it's crucial to underline a key difference between ourselves and our robot counterparts: AI, in all its glory, is designed to seek the shortest, most efficient routes. This is its strength. It can evaluate thousands, even millions, of potential paths in the blink of an eye and choose the most "efficient" one. Yet, as we all know, the most efficient solution is not always the most creative one. In fact, I'd argue that the route of greatest efficiency is rarely the most impactful. It might prevent us from reaching a more creatively meaningful destination.

"The route of greatest efficiency is rarely the most impactful."

John Maeda, VP Engineering, Head of Computational Design / AI Platform

Part of being efficiency-oriented means that AI is constantly seeking out the most common, expected path. By repeating tried and tested solutions, AI is inherently more risk-averse. Particularly when paired with strict guardrails and considerations of AI safety, it will almost always opt for the lowest risk. In many cases in life, that's a really good thing. However, in the realm of creativity, higher risk may lead to an unexpected higher reward. When people take risks and go out on a limb, they're forced to think strategically under pressure, yielding unexpected results. What's that old saying? "Burn the ships!" When there's no turning back with a high-risk decision, things get really interesting quickly.

Humans are innately driven to take the adventurous, longer route. Our distinct traits of creativity, innovation, and uphill thinking compel us to explore the unseen, unheard, and untouched, even when it's seen as rationally "wrong" by conventional standards. This shared spirit, found in entrepreneurs, athletes, and artists alike, is demonstrated in our history of remarkable art, groundbreaking discoveries, and revolutionary innovations. This willingness to embrace challenges, endure setbacks, and choose "longcuts" over shortcuts underscores our unique capacity for uphill thinking. Even as AI excels at efficiently executing repetitive tasks, it remains rightfully constrained by our design for safety and lower risks, making it less suited for the daringly imaginative and transformative tasks that creatives undertake. This courage to venture in unconventional directions, to bet the farm on an irrational path, is what differentiates us from today's AI. The uphill thinking that may seem suboptimal in an AI-centric view is, in essence, the core of human creativity.

"It's time to burn our ships" is a phrase that means the company must cut off all avenues to the old ways of doing things. As leaders taking our people into unknown and potentially hazardous new territories like explorer Hernán Cortés did, we need to ensure those we lead understand there is no turning back.

Or saying it in *Star Trek* parlance, to quote my favorite line between Captain Kirk and Captain Picard:

Kirk: I take it the odds are against us and the situation is grim.

Picard: You could say that.

Kirk: You know, if Spock were here, he'd say that I was an irrational, illogical human being by taking on a mission like that. Sounds like fun!

One may ask: Can an AI truly understand the suboptimal, winding, long, hard, high-risk, and effortful journey that humans take to yield great output? To an extent. It's important to remember that AI is not a sentient being. Currently, there is no direct 1:1 notion of "understanding" in an AI the same way that we humans understand a concept. Instead, AI can be instructed to do things with specificity. Do this thing, don't do that thing. In that way, it's no different than computer programming of the past.

What is different is that this kind of programming feels a bit like being powered by Vibranium, the Marvel universe metal with alien properties. It's a momentous shift, one that has supercharged our technology to a point nearly beyond comprehension. We've had similar shifts in the past: There was a time when electricity was the day's Vibranium. In a world powered by steam engines, the introduction of technology that was completely invisible caused immense excitement and fear. Steam power posed a frightening disruption for the textile industry, as new mills could easily fabricate textiles that would have taken humans months and years to create.

In response to this industrial revolution, artisans and leaders founded a revolution of their own in the form of the Arts and Crafts movement, which advocated for “products that not only had more integrity but which were also made in a less dehumanizing way.” Some of their fiercest supporters, self-proclaimed Luddites, would engage in “frame breaking” (i.e. destroying an automated weaving machine), often getting jailed and fined as a result. But what’s important about the Arts and Crafts movement is how it led to an enlightenment of objects that could only be created by human beings: textiles, furniture, and other items that were so intricately created that no machine could possibly manufacture them.

This reverence for human creativity was also reflected in the educational institutions founded during this time, such as the Rhode Island School of Design (RISD). They pioneered the use of the first wave of “generative art software” in the form of punch cards for Jacquard looms—the GPUs of the day—and designed distinctive textile patterns that married artistry with new technology.

Fast-forward to today, and RISD continues to champion the ethos of the Arts and Crafts movement, serving as a bastion of uphill thinking in our modern digital age. At RISD, students are taught to embrace the complexity of the design process, to not shy away from the long, winding road of creative discovery. This attitude prepares them to venture beyond the efficiency-driven solutions offered by AI and to craft designs with a level of nuance and authenticity that only human touch can achieve.

So where does AI fit into all this? In the same spaces where efficiency and precision thrive. AI’s proficiency in automation, data analysis, and pattern recognition can streamline mundane tasks, freeing up more time for us to focus on the aspects that demand human ingenuity. We’ve entered a similar age as John Ruskin and William Morris, when we need to create things, software, and experiences that only we humans can guide in their evolution. By leveraging AI, we can not only retire our drudgery, but we also amplify our uphill thinking, taking on greater challenges and achieving unprecedented heights.

John Ruskin and William Morris were influential 19th-century British artists, writers, and social reformers who were key figures in the Arts and Crafts movement.

The problems we solve today in design have already changed by the time they've been addressed. Thus we need to be investing more time and energy into the ever-changing task of seeking and identifying new problems to solve, ones that lead to better outcomes for people. Part of that is continuing to find better ways to work well together, until we're all working as teams of eminently capable professionals who can finish each other's sentences.

"By leveraging AI, we can not only retire our drudgery, but we also amplify our uphill thinking, taking on greater challenges and achieving unprecedented heights."

John Maeda, VP Engineering, Head of Computational Design / AI Platform

The more we pedal uphill—navigating the journey, embracing the struggle, and rejoicing in the climb—with AI empowering us to spend more time on that journey, it's more of a win-win relationship we will build with AI in the creative fields. It gives us more time to take in the scenery and identify opportunities for exploration that may lie just off the beaten path. It frees us to focus on the things that only humans can do: spend a little bit more time than is strictly necessary, in order to end up somewhere unexpected.

How LinkedIn, Asana, and Duolingo build AI features users want and trust

Suzanne LaBarre, Editor of Co. Design

Eight product managers provide a framework for gauging whether an AI feature should get the green light.

Despite myriad practical challenges—not to mention a slew of moral, ethical, and environmental concerns—AI has the potential to shape the future of work, and the future of design and product development in particular. If harnessed carefully, the hype can even be a catalyst. But how do you transform all that momentum into tangible product features that people actually want and need? To find out, we talked to our colleagues here at Figma, plus product leaders at companies with a track record of shipping successful AI-driven products.



1 Start with user problems.

The feverish drumbeat surrounding AI may put pressure on teams to launch a feature before they fully flesh out a logical use case. Put bluntly: Just because AI can power some new party trick doesn't mean it should. "AI is a hammer and everybody is looking for nails," says Conor Woods, Product Manager at Figma. "You really just have to start with problems that people are facing and then think about the best way that you might want to approach those and see if there is a role that AI can play."

In our [AI + Design report](#), over 20% of respondents building products or features that include AI say not solving a user need or problem is a top challenge.

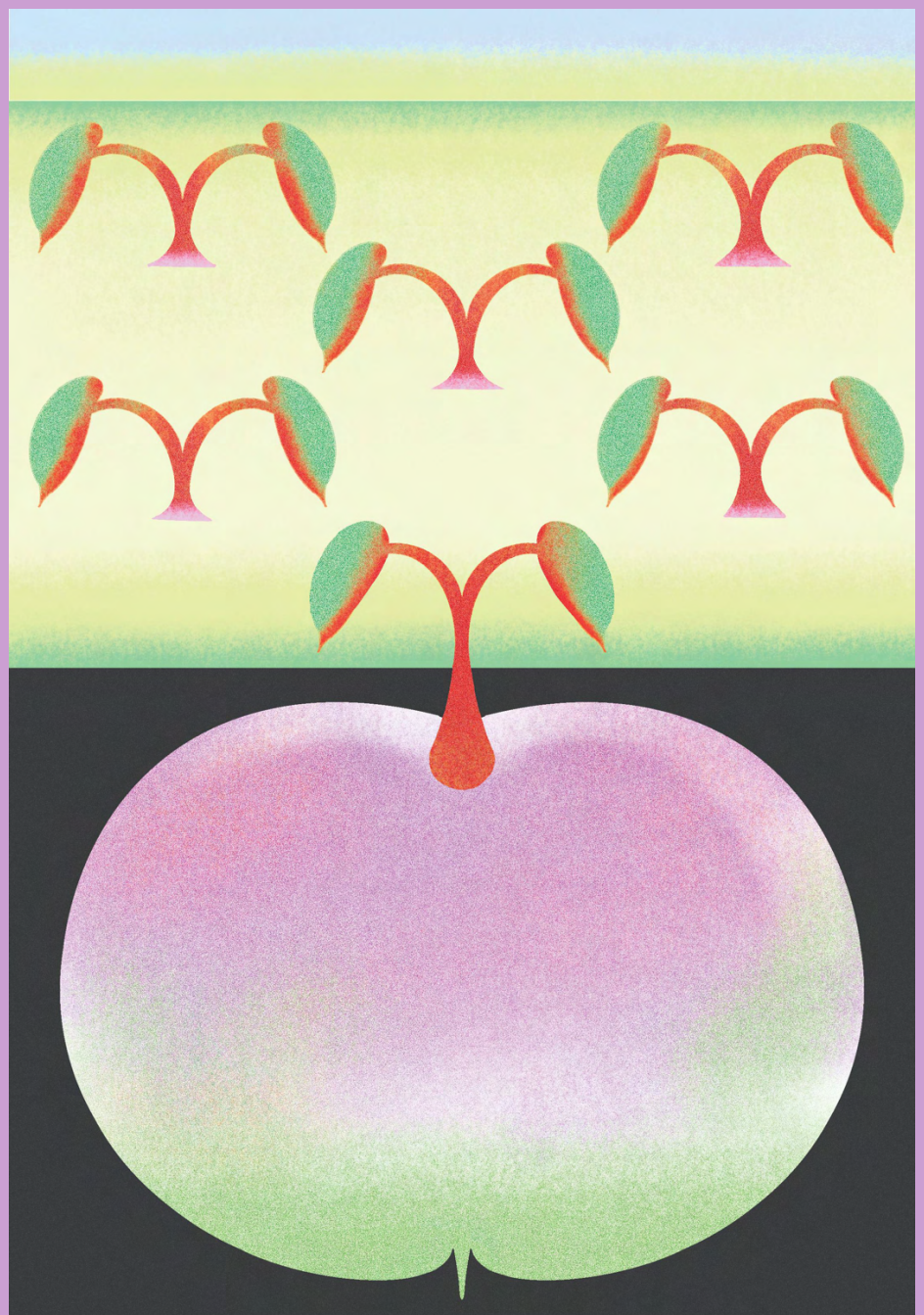
"AI is a hammer and everybody is looking for nails."

Conor Woods, Product Manager, Figma

Conor asks three questions to determine if a feature benefits from AI. First, are you working on a problem that can take advantage of an existing large data set? LLMs like OpenAI's GPT-4 are perfect for organizing information that's already out there—generating summaries, for example—but it's hard to get them to come up with entirely new experiences, which is essentially a prompt engineering challenge. Second: Are you okay with a margin of error?

Imperfect (and sometimes outright false) results are inevitable when you're working with today's LLMs. So a problem that requires 100% accuracy won't be sufficiently addressed by AI. Third: Are you using AI to paper over bad UX? As a point of comparison, Conor cites bloated mobile devices, with endless rows of apps forcing you to ask a smart assistant like Siri to find what you need. Another app doesn't improve the underlying flaw. Similarly, adding AI won't fix an ill-conceived ecosystem.

At Asana, teams have an even simpler test for judging whether AI makes sense or not: Does it save users time? One feature, called Smart Status, enables customers to write status updates with the help of AI so they can get a draft going in seconds. "They already write status updates," says Rodrigo Davies, Director of Product Management, AI at Asana. "They can right away go from 'I spend 20 minutes a week doing this' to 'Now I'm going to spend two minutes per week.' The ROI is super clear to them." Nail first, hammer second.



2 Specify the problem. No really, get specific!

In the design and development process, AI's greatest asset can also be a liability. "Generative AI features, by their nature, satisfy many different underlying needs," says Cemre Güngör, a Product Manager at Figma. But that creates ambiguity when you're trying to define a feature. "When you describe an AI feature with words ('we'll summarize text'), everyone ends up with a slightly different interpretation in their head for what it should do," he says. "There's actually a ton of nuance. For a summary, the underlying need might be understanding what a document was about, identifying action items, or finding the most salient quotes in research."

"When you describe an AI feature with words, everyone ends up with a slightly different interpretation in their head for what it should do. There's actually a ton of nuance."

Cemre Güngör, Product Manager, Figma

Cemre says that the best way to ensure an AI project doesn't go off the rails is to be aggressively specific upfront about what you want it to achieve. Write out the precise prompts and outputs you have in mind. "Writing concrete examples helps everyone on your team align on exactly what you expect from the feature and can help you better define the problem you're trying to solve," he says. "And as you're moving through implementation, they can serve as a guidepost on whether you're on the right track."

3 Think outside the (chat)box.

Much of AI today lives inside chatboxes. This makes sense to some extent. Apps based on LLMs are good at generating text, which flows logically in a chat interface. Plus, ChatGPT—originally built on GPT3—was most consumers' introduction to AI apps. But chatboxes aren't always the best way to convey information. "We're stuck in chatboxes. Just like we're stuck in Zoom right now," says Figma's Daniel Mejia. "There are so many missed opportunities when we 'talk' to ChatGPT—what identity it has, how contextual it can be."

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Daniel Mejia, Software Engineering Manager, Figma

Duolingo, which uses AI to help language learners understand their mistakes and practice real-world conversations, originally went "all in on chat," says Edwin Bodge, Group PM of Revenue and Subscriptions at Duolingo. But a simple chat interface didn't adequately engage users. Duolingo sees itself as competing with big, splashy social media companies, not just other language-learning apps, so it has to dazzle its audience. "Learners are so much more comfortable interacting with something that looks like a rich UI, a delightful UI," Edwin says. "We fully moved some of our features away from a chat interface and toward what they're used to interacting with."

4 Put people in the driver seat.

AI's potential to disrupt entire industries may inspire fear, prompting some people to dismiss it outright. "Most customers are what we call excito-nervous," says Asana's Rodrigo Davies. "'Maybe this can do something for me, but maybe it's going to break things.' We have to win customers' trust."

Reminding users that they're in charge can go a long way toward building that trust. "I don't think it's AI or human-centered design; it should always start with human-centered design," says Shyvee Shi, Product Lead at LinkedIn. "One way is bringing transparency to this black box [that is] AI." LinkedIn, for example, uses AI to help recruiters craft messages to potential candidates, but reveals what kinds of fields the AI is using and lets recruiters pick and choose the fields. That creates a sense of agency; users benefit from automation but don't relinquish their control over the final product. "You can automate a ton of stuff," she says. "But the human needs to be in the driver seat."

"I don't think it's AI or human-centered design; it should always start with human-centered design. One way is bringing transparency to this black box [that is] AI."

Shyvee Shi, Product Lead, LinkedIn

5 Embrace the chaos. Give yourself time to explore.

In many ways, AI requires an entirely new way of working. "Product development for AI works quite differently from non-AI work. It is very non-deterministic," says Figma Product Manager Albert Song. "You make one change and it could regress other things, and you're not sure exactly why, and you have to just try to figure it out and test different ideas. It's not straightforward."

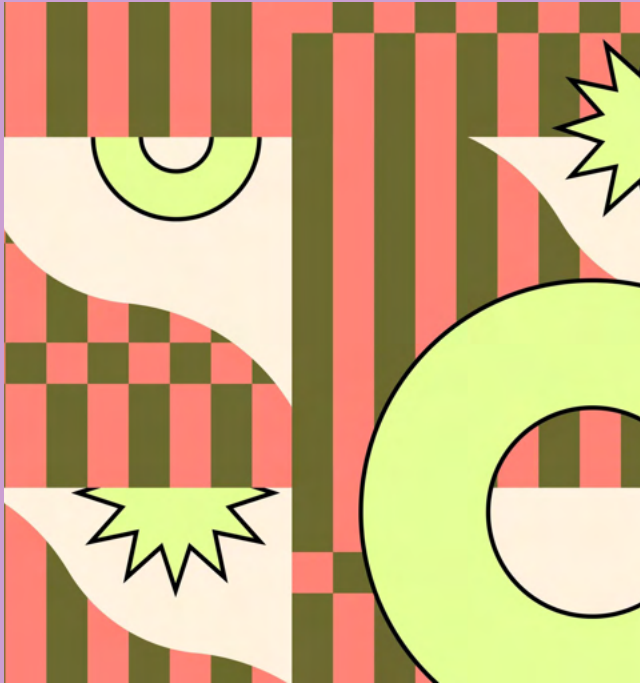
"Product development for AI works quite differently. It is very non-deterministic."

Albert Song, Product Manager, Figma

Albert and his colleagues experienced this firsthand when they started exploring [FigJam AI](#). After an initial period of moving quickly, they faced one stumbling block after another. "It actually got really, really scary because we ran into a lot of hurdles," Figma's Conor Woods says. "We'd make improvements somewhere and quite literally take one step forward, and two steps back."

To work through it, they deputized engineers to become subject matter experts in specific problem areas and addressed them one by one. Eventually, they were able to regain their footing. But the experience taught them that they couldn't rely on a traditional product development process, in which you identify bugs and fix them. With AI, Albert says, the path is much more circuitous. "You have to bake in time for exploratory work. It pays off in the end."

AI + design: Figma users tell us what's coming next



AI + design: Navigating the promises and pitfalls of AI



Stripe and Intuit on why the future of design systems is automated

Carly Ayres, Content Strategist at Figma

As the world of design grows increasingly complex, a new class of tools is emerging to help teams navigate the landscape.

From AI-assisted design to plugins and widgets, automation is reshaping the way we approach design systems, raising existential questions about the role of designers and developers. What does this mean for the future of our practice and the industry as a whole?

The history of plugins and widgets is deeply entwined with design, with some of the earliest ones built in the 1970s for publishing software on Apple's Macintosh computer. Since then, many software companies have encouraged user-created add-ons, fostering entire microeconomies and communities in the process.

Plugins for design systems typically fall into two categories: those that automate existing tasks and those that extend feature sets. Across Figma's Community pages, icon and image generators that streamline asset creation are some of the most popular plugins. Others automate flows, convert designs to code, or create presentations. The common thread? Reducing complexity and friction in workflows.

Matthew Ström, a design system leader at Stripe, explains, "Low- or no-code testing and automation tools can make it substantially faster and can save design systems teams uncountably many hours of manual work." Anyone who has ever experienced a bout of carpal tunnel, or perused the search results page for "ergonomic keyboard designs," is likely familiar with the acute, physical pain that can accompany many repetitive design tasks. While there are countless reasons to pursue a career in design, pushing pixels is usually not one of them.

"Low- or no-code testing and automation tools can save design systems teams uncountably many hours of manual work."

Matthew Ström, design system leader, Stripe

When tools lack certain features, plugins can bridge those gaps, too. Stark is a product company shipping an integrated accessibility suite, which plugs into the tools product teams already use. “The whole philosophy is that we hook into the tools that your product team is already using, whether you’re the designer, developer, project manager, or QA expert, and stitch them together into an accessibility workflow,” explains Stark’s Chief Design Officer Benedikt Lehnert.

If plugins skew toward functionality, widgets excel at interactive visualizations. Popular widgets for design systems include charts, buttons, device frames, and tables for organizing component properties. They augment the in-app experience itself, like a device frame widget providing a quick way to sketch interfaces without needing to scour the world wide web for a clean phone wireframe.

In both cases, plugins and widgets meet users where they are, extending the capabilities and ease-of-use of design systems. But these tools are only as powerful as their inputs. This is where AI comes in, providing a new foundation for functionality and usability.

Kaelig Deloumeau-Prigent, founder of the [Design Tokens W3C Community Group](#), sees great potential for AI in design system workflows, envisioning the same kind of human-computer collaboration exemplified by tools like GitHub’s Copilot: “There are so many explorations that can be guided through AI...I want to see that same kind of collaboration with technology for design systems.”

Kaelig thinks better token management systems will help lower barriers to entry in the coming years, as current solutions often require considerable technical expertise: “For some teams, that’s a barrier they might not be able to overcome.” He sees AI-assisted design as the area where tokens will be most impactful moving forward.

In a 2021 panel, Soleio predicted, "We should expect to see substantial progress in how design exploration and feedback becomes increasingly automated. I anticipate that we will find ourselves in a future where more knowledge work, feedback, and iterations will happen through virtual collaborators: non-human agents that are well-tuned to the types of tasks we manually do today."

"I anticipate that we will find ourselves in a future where more knowledge work, feedback, and iterations will happen through virtual collaborators."

Soleio, designer and investor

As AI evolves, we may see it help extend design systems to rapidly assemble interfaces, identify potential issues, and provide guidance on usage and compliance. However, Sam Anderson, Director of Design at Intuit, believes design will remain a critical human activity: "It would be hard to create an AI that would figure out the customer problem, figure out the right thing from the catalog that might solve that customer problem, and render it on-screen in the right way. We still need human designers to do that."

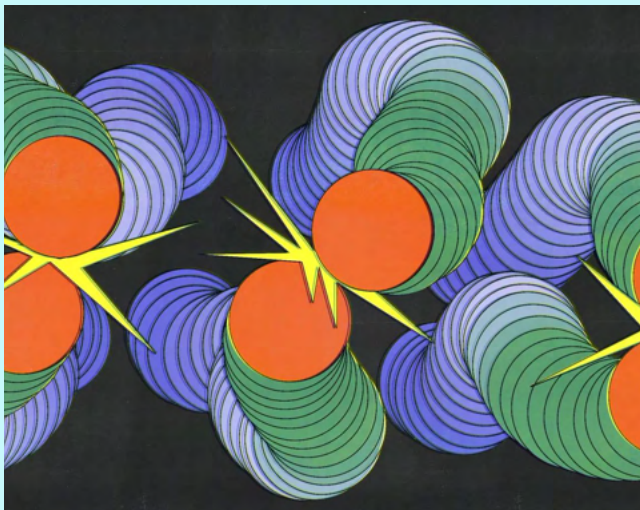
In fact, the demand for designers is likely to increase as new environments like Web3 and the Metaverse emerge. Andrew Hogan, who leads insights at Figma, suggests that "as design links more with code and design systems get easier to use and more accepted, more people can create passable interfaces. However, there will be more demand for great interactions and for new, interesting interactions. The desire for companies to stand out and create status and differentiation suggests that there will be even more demand for designers."

As we look to the future, it's clear that automation will play an increasingly important role in design systems. Plugins, widgets, and AI-powered tools will continue to evolve, offering new ways to streamline workflows, extend capabilities, and push the boundaries of what's possible. At the same time, human designers will remain essential, bringing creativity, empathy, and critical thinking to the table as they tackle ever-more complex challenges.

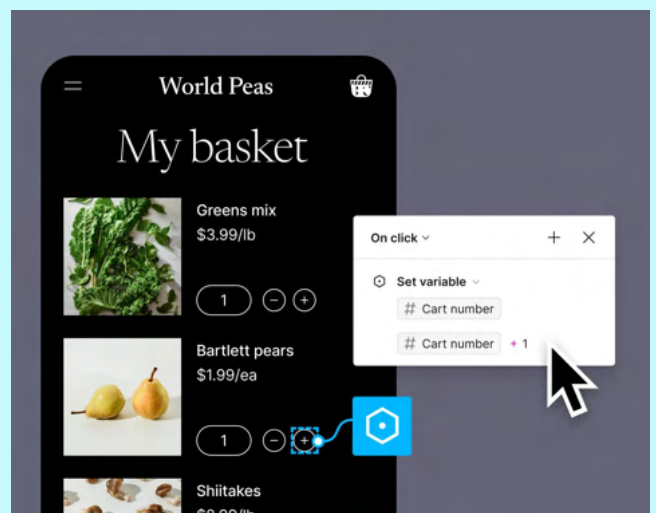
Perhaps the real question is how design systems teams will learn to work alongside machines. By embracing the power of automation while recognizing its limitations, designers can focus on what they do best: solving problems, exploring new directions, and creating differentiated, engaging experiences. In doing so, they will not only adapt to the changing landscape but help shape it, ensuring that design remains a vital, human-driven endeavor in the age of automation.

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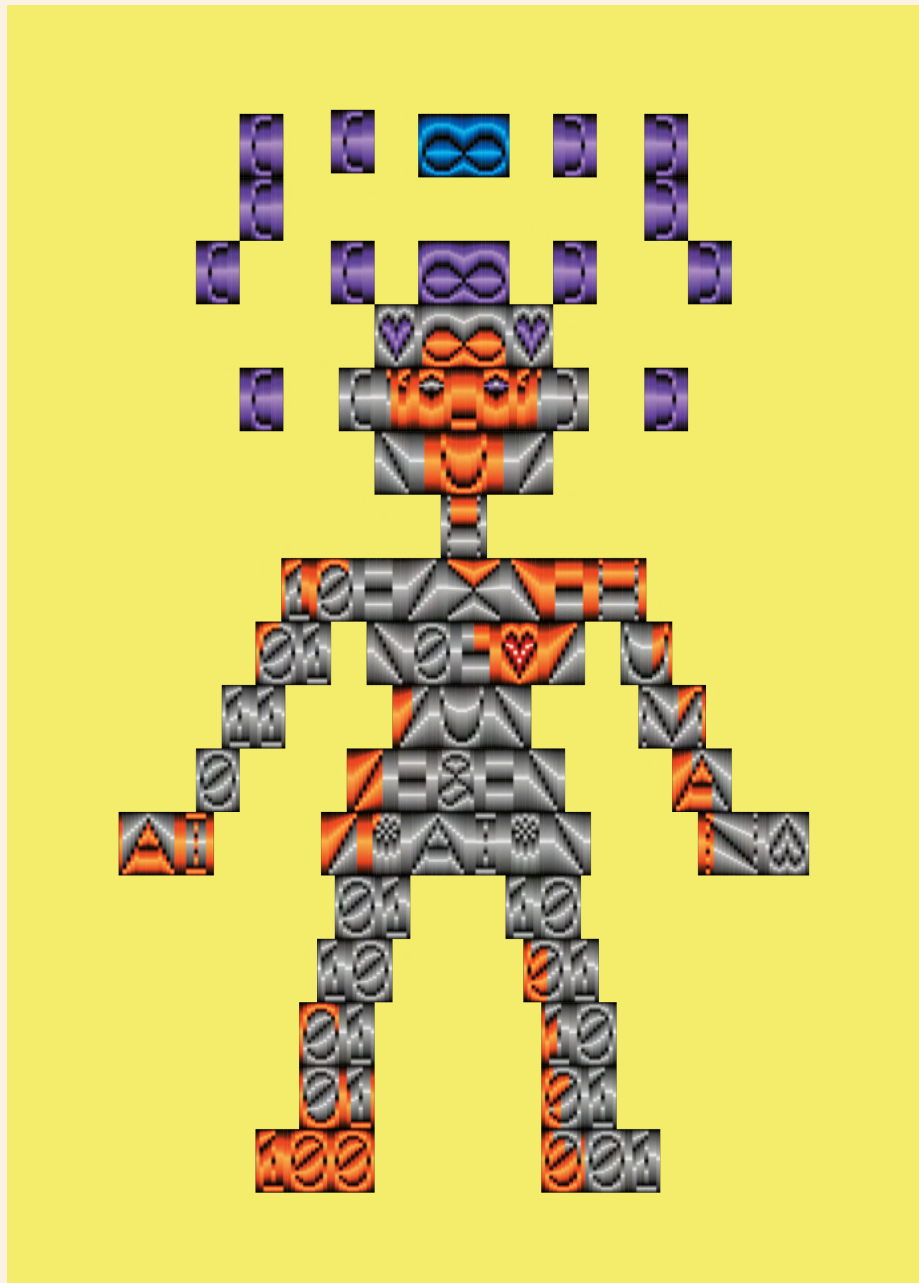


Inside Perplexity's product design philosophy

Alia Fite, Content Strategist at Figma

Co-founder and CEO Aravind Srinivas wants Perplexity to be not only a resource, but an engine for curiosity.

If you ask the search platform Perplexity how Perplexity works, it says: "Perplexity AI combines natural language processing, web indexing, LLMs, and transparent sourcing to deliver accurate, up-to-date answers by seamlessly integrating web search and conversational AI capabilities." If you ask Perplexity Co-founder and CEO Aravind Srinivas, it's an "answer engine." This distillation is a nod to Aravind's vision for a knowledge app that synthesizes relevant information from around the web instead of returning an exhaustive list of links. We sat down with him to learn how Perplexity delivers information at the right altitude, the relationship between footnotes and sources, and why catering to our collective curiosity is a personal endeavor.



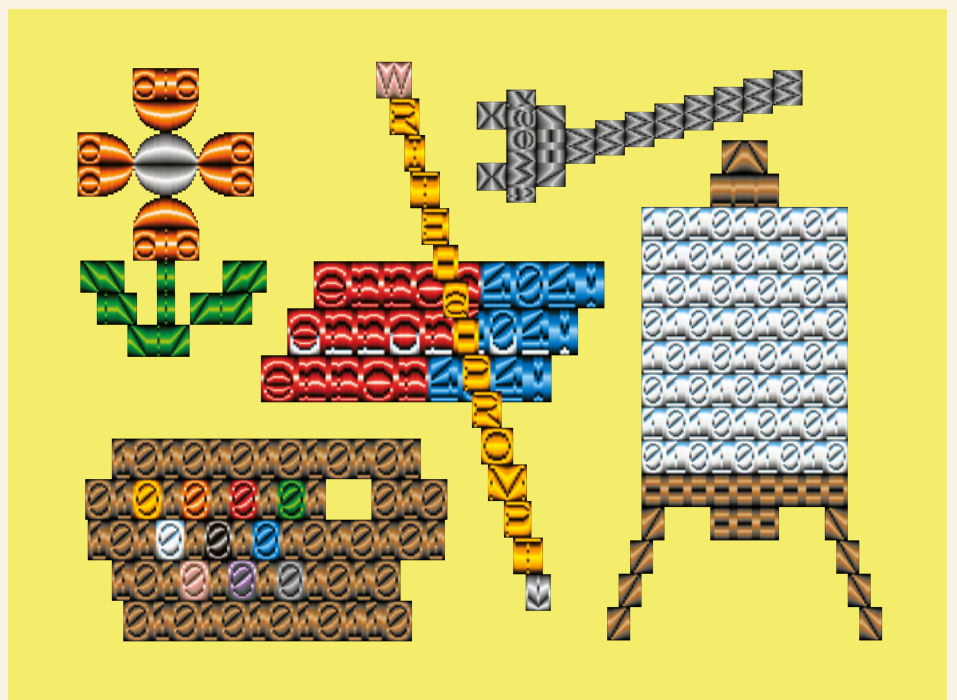
What led you to build Perplexity?

As a kid, I would spend a lot of time in Wikipedia rabbit holes clicking on links. Perplexity is kind of built for those Wiki nerds. Back in the day, encyclopedias were big volumes of books; then they became CDs, DVDs, pen drives, Wikipedia, and now Perplexity.

We want to be the reference for others by building an app that delivers accurate information and knowledge. We want to make learning fun and interesting. Everybody talks about making mobile apps engaging, but that doesn't need to be done through dancing videos. It can be done through making people curious. So catering to humanity's curiosity is a big overarching goal for us, and that starts with allowing people to ask whatever they want without any fear of being judged.

"Everybody talks about making mobile apps engaging, but that doesn't need to be done through dancing videos. It can be done through making people curious."

Aravind Srinivas, Co-founder and CEO, Perplexity



How did building Perplexity ease your own fear of judgment?

My co-founders and I were first-time entrepreneurs and didn't have any company or product building experience, so we built a Slackbot to answer our own questions—like understanding the different mechanisms to do fundraising, or how to set up health insurance for our employees. It was so useful, but we never had the courage to launch it. We were always worried about what people would think about us. Would they think we are that audacious to compete with Google?

And then one of our investors, Nat Friedman, said, "Why are you taking yourselves so seriously? You have literally nothing to lose. The worst case outcome is actually progress from where you are, and the best case is that it takes off and becomes the next big thing." And I think that appealed to me—that sort of asymmetric bet where loss is fine and a win is amazing. We launched a week after ChatGPT.

"What if we literally gave you the answer, but also gave you the sources so that it's as accurate and as grounded in facts as possible?"

Aravind Srinivas, Co-founder and CEO, Perplexity

How did that timing inform the big decisions you made around how Perplexity works?

ChatGPT clearly established in everybody's mind that there was a knowledge cut-off; it would hallucinate and answer the wrong things. So we came up with a different twist: What if we literally gave you the answer, but also gave you the sources so that it's as accurate and as grounded in facts as possible? And what if we built a UI that truly speaks to the user? In fact, I've heard one user describe Perplexity as Wikipedia and chat coming together and having a baby. The only difference is that the data for it comes from the whole internet.

How do you think about making information approachable without being reductive?

I was once at Sam Altman's house and noticed that he had a lot of books. I said, "You have no time to read all these books. Why do you even have them?" He told me, "You don't need to read more than 20 pages. You read the intro, the first chapter, you get the 80/20." The idea is that you get most of the value of the book very quickly. That's what Perplexity wants to establish for you.

Let's say I want to understand LLMs. I just need to understand 20% of the bits to get 80% of the understanding, and that can be achieved through a tool like Perplexity that sources content from many different web pages, picks the most important things, and forms a concise answer.

How does Perplexity balance answering someone's question with encouraging further curiosity?

After an answer to a query, you see three related questions. My hypothesis is that every person is extremely curious, but most of us don't have the inclination to channel it. Even if we do, we don't have the ability to articulate what we're curious about. Good questions are not that frequent. That's why "Let Me Google That for You" exists. That's where we can really help people.

A good question is very personal to your understanding of the topic. Maybe you're trying to understand black holes. Some physicists might be at the PhD level. The AI has to know that a user wants something at this granularity. We don't blame the human for not being able to come up with a good, precise question. We always work with the product design philosophy that the human is never wrong. The burden is on the AI, not on us. That's a true copilot.

What's a bug that you're currently working through?

When there isn't enough information, the model doesn't say, "Hey, we don't have enough data, and I can't make a conclusion." If you ask a question like, "Who won the Olympics in 2028?" it might give you an answer based on a snippet from a previous time when the U.S. won. Those sorts of reasoning skills are what we need to keep working on.

"My hypothesis is that every person is extremely curious, but most of us don't have the inclination to channel it."

Aravind Srinivas, Co-founder and CEO, Perplexity

What differentiates Perplexity from other AI tools?

With Perplexity, one part is about facts—responding to a query by pulling in relevant documents from the web—and the other part is about reasoning—synthesizing those documents in a concise way, with appropriate references. We train Perplexity for the skill of taking in a bunch of information, a bunch of snippets, and then synthesizing a concise answer.

That's what's different from other generative AI companies that are either focused on building one bot that does everything, or on one particular vertical. Perplexity is horizontal in terms of how many different professions can use the product, but vertical in terms of the use case we focus on.

How big is the gap between how AI works in theory and how we're able to use it in practice today?

We are all talking about scenarios where AI agents will take over. But can I have AI reliably find a restaurant for me? It's not a simple case of finding where there are spots available on Google Maps. The next scenario is an AI agent understands you're looking for a dinner reservation, goes to your calendar, finds the free slots in the restaurant, and sees what overlaps. If there are no open slots, it calls the restaurant and gets the details about the wait time, or looks for an alternate place. This is the iterative, multistep reasoning that today's models aren't able to do.

What is the promise of AI?

If AI really works, life will be simple for a lot of us. AI will be personalized to us. You won't have to do all of these burdensome tasks. And if that's available to every person on the planet in an affordable manner, our world will be a much better place. AI is an equalizing force: It gives everyone superpowers.

"We always work with the product design philosophy that the human is never wrong. The burden is on the AI, not on us. That's a true copilot."

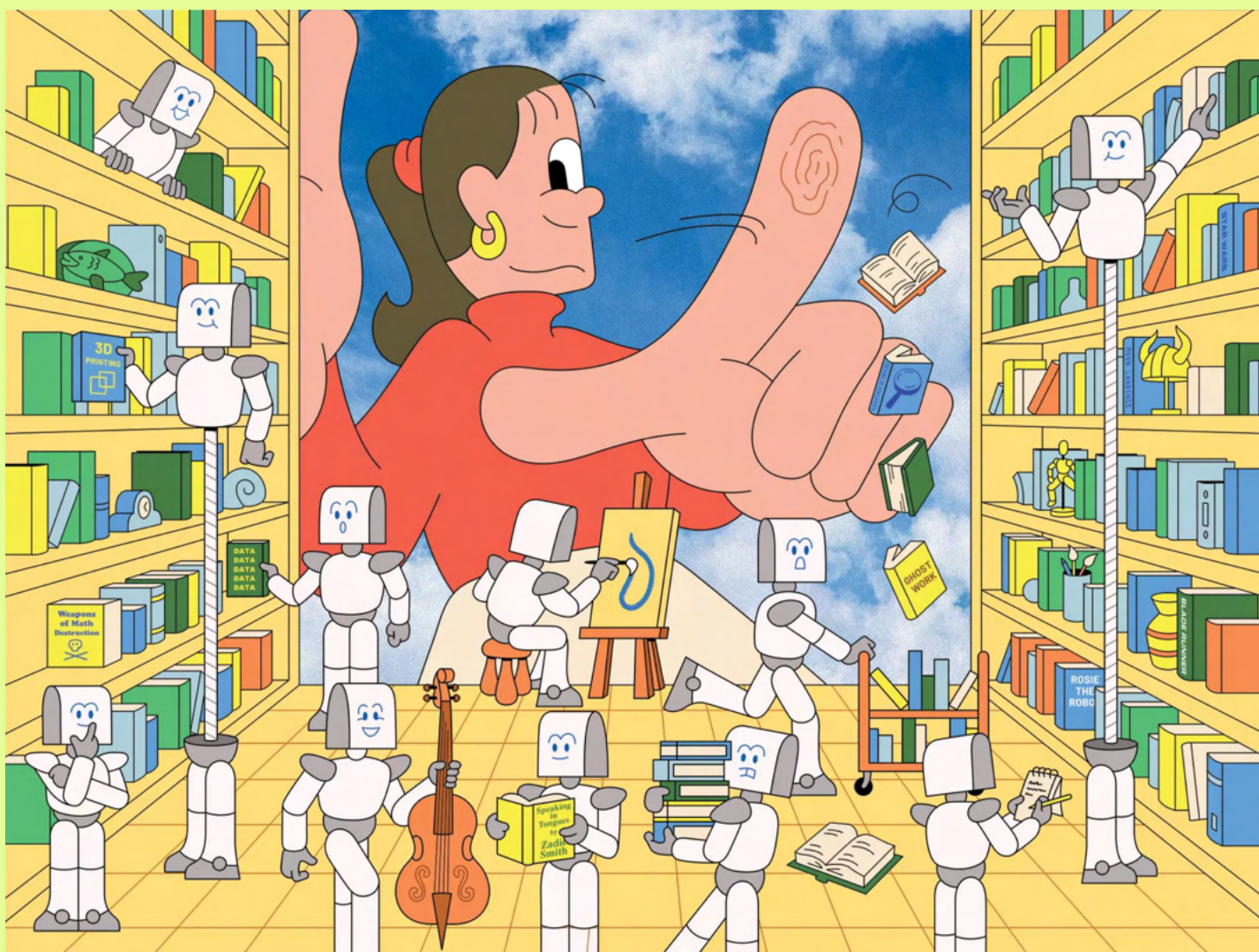
Aravind Srinivas, Co-founder and CEO, Perplexity

Google's Ovetta Sampson on the importance of quality data

Herbert Lui, Content Strategist at Figma

As many focus on the possibilities and limitations of AI tools and their output, Ovetta Sampson reminds us to pay attention to the power of the input.

After two decades in journalism, and the last five years in tech leadership roles, Ovetta Sampson knows a thing or two about navigating the human experience. As Director of User Experience Machine Learning at Google, she leads a team aiming to make ML and AI accessible and useful to more people. While many focus on how to build more powerful models and AI features, Ovetta continues to champion the importance of what she calls minimum viable data, data that is fully representative of the end user as well as the business. We sat down with Ovetta to learn more about how quality data is essential for building quality AI.



You helped create the design industry's first set of AI ethics principles, which sheds light on how people influence data. What are some of your biggest takeaways from that work?

There's an idea in technology that we measure what matters. If we're not measured, do we exist? And if we don't exist, how can we ensure we're not harmed by the model's outcomes? Sometimes, product builders either leave out the people, or they over-index on the data—they forget that those data points are connected to human beings. The result is traumatized data sets—data infused with the trauma of social, cultural, and economic practices.

"Sometimes, product builders either leave out the people, or they over-index on the data—they forget that those data points are connected to human beings."

Ovetta Sampson, Director of User Experience Machine Learning, Google

Consider the pool of mortgage data that make up credit worthiness models. The math formula that underlies FICO scores was written in 1958, but women couldn't buy mortgages or sign for credit cards until the 1970s. Similarly, the oldest data set that we have is the U.S. Census, which began in 1790 and didn't recognize LGBTQ individuals until 2021. So what happened? Did they exist before that? The worst thing you can do with ML and AI is be careless about the data—the people—you omit.

Minimum viable data is a call to product builders to pay attention to the quality of the data a product needs to make its business case, and to consider if ML and AI are the right tools for the challenge. There is no AI and ML without data, and there is no data without people. That data was generated, created, engineered, and transformed by a human.

What challenges do you see between people and data in the current state of ML and AI?

The quality of an AI's output depends 99.9% on the input—namely, the data. The power is in the input. I could give you a prediction of how your model is going to behave based upon the data set that you train it with. The input is what creates these model outcomes; there's nothing else to talk about, to be quite frank.

Who gets to decide what's good or bad? Who gets to decide what gets into the input? Who gets to decide how much data they need to be able to solve a problem? Those are the fundamental questions.

"There is no AI and ML without data, and there is no data without people."

Ovetta Sampson, Director of User Experience Machine Learning, Google

How do you teach future product builders the importance of quality data?

I teach my students to inspect their data sets and look for what's missing. For example, every time someone registers a data set, they should also produce a data card, a document explaining processes and rationale that shape the data, to answer questions such as who collected the data, who transformed the data, and where the data is housed, amongst many other factors. When their models start acting funny, companies refer to these data cards to trace it back to the source.

So when we think about the minimum viable data, what is the problem you're trying to solve? What is the applicability and desirability of both ML and AI? Just because you can use AI or ML, does it mean you should? And is the data that's going to be used to solve this problem indeed

equitable and of high quality? Is it the minimum viable solution you need to solve this problem and not raise the human engagement risks? So those are the things you need to consider. Right? When you're like, "I'm going to use ML and AI to solve a problem." Well, who are you solving it for? And that goes back to the data that you're collecting.

"So when we think about the minimum viable data, what is the problem you're trying to solve? What is the applicability and desirability of both ML and AI? Just because you can use AI or ML, does it mean you should?"

Ovetta Sampson, Director of User Experience Machine Learning, Google

How can we put ourselves back in the driver's seat as AI technology continues to accelerate?

For so long, the public has been silent on ML and AI, but now you and I have access to it. We can control the software. With generative AI, we can build anything we want just by talking. Now that more of us have been exposed to AI, we'll realize our place in it. The box is open, and now that people are aware, next comes advocacy. One great start is just to be aware of how important you are to these industries. You have a role in this technology, not just as a consumer.

"Now that more of us have been exposed to AI, we'll realize our place in it. The box is open, and now that people are aware, next comes advocacy."

Ovetta Sampson, Director of User Experience Machine Learning, Google



The power and efficacy of AI hinges on its human operators. At its worst, AI can feel tacked on or counterintuitive. At its best, however, AI alleviates tedium and empowers us to do our most creative work. As product leaders, our job is to think critically about when and how the technology should come into play, which calls for a clear-eyed view of its evolving possibilities and limitations.

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